

21 June 2003

Dear Jen,

It's so hot today and I don't have any water. We are limited to two bottles of water per day, and the rest has to come from the water buffalo, which is steaming hot of course. At dinner I went out and filled up a bottle with water and put it in the freezer so that it could cool off. It is quite frankly impossible to drink the steam that comes straight out of the buffalo. When I went over to get the water, my bottle was no longer there. I am so pissed—I can't even be nice to anyone. I'm just in one of those moods. I made Sergeant Franklin take down his fly paper ribbon and have been snappy.

It didn't start with the water though. First, I woke up with this panicky feeling like I will be stuck in this routine forever. Forever waking up in Iraq and dodging the heat, fighting off lack of motivation to squeeze out a tough, sweaty work out with tank gears in a poorly ventilated room. I felt panicked—like I would never escape reporting into the TOC at two in the afternoon and being confined to this little white hole in the wall for twelve hours. I would never escape the beads of sweat I get just sitting around, the relentless flies, or the total, and utter boredom.

I went to SSG Hodge's room and watched "Remember the Titans" on his miniature DVD player. For a while I was content watching the movie, but the little fold out chair and tiny screen never allowed me to fully escape my surroundings. I then, got ready for work and had to chase down the power cord to my computer which SSG Hodge had borrowed to charge his own. I guess SSG Binda broke SSG Hodge's cord and he needs my cable to make his computer work. It was the second time in as many days that I had to go chase down my own equipment.

When I came to work, I found out that we did not receive a water resupply again today and there was absolutely no bottled water in the TOC. I had to scrounge up a bottle so that I could go fill it with steaming hot buffalo water which I drank simply because I was dying of thirst. Then the boredom set in again. I can't escape it.

By four-thirty, Captain Hamilton had not yet returned my computer to me and my frustration began to set in again. The captains borrow the computer everyday to watch movies, and I really don't mind, but today I am just in a bad mood. The bottom line is that when nobody had brought it back and the Brigade Commander's Update was about to start, I was not happy. All this, coupled with someone stealing my water has me pretty sour, yet the flies won't stop flying around and landing on me. I threw the fly swatter to the other side of the room and now I don't want to go get it. Argh.

It is a new day. Today is the 22nd of June, and I never got back to writing the rest of this letter yesterday. I am getting ready to take the down the minutes of the Brigade BUB; it will start in ten minutes. The last four hours have been spent arguing with Sergeant Franklin. He presents himself as a wannabe black guy, even though he is from Alabama. He started the whole thing by stating that I try to be a gangster in my Ford Explorer. I